



HAMSTER · MESOCRICETUS AURATUS

Keep your hamster the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the enclosure the starter kit isn't, bedding deep enough to burrow in, wet tail recognized on sight, and the routines that make a short life a good one.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every measurement in inches and centimetres, and every portion by species
- ✓ The bedding depth study, with the three numbers that reorder everything
- ✓ Wet tail on its own page, because it kills in 24 to 48 hours
- ✓ Printable emergency card, pet-sitter sheet, and a torpor checklist

42 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 6 through 8 before buying anything, and read page 10 before choosing which hamster. The enclosure and the bedding are the two decisions that are expensive to redo, and the pet-shop starter kit gets both wrong: it is too small to hold the floor space, and too shallow to hold the bedding. Buy the enclosure once, from page 27, and buy it bigger than the kit.

If your hamster is already here

Go to the Setup Checklist on page 25 and audit what you have, starting with bedding depth, which is the single highest-value change available to you. If your hamster is chewing the bars, that is a husbandry readout rather than a personality trait and page 17 explains what changed it in the research. And if there is any wetness or matting around its rear end, stop reading and go to page 19: that is a same-day emergency.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 25: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 32: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 26: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 33: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 29: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 34: Equipment, Cleaning & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 30: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

A hamster is the cheapest animal in this series to buy and the one most often underfunded once it is home. Housing standards have moved a long way from the wire cage with a plastic tube, and the bedding depth research on page 17 is the clearest welfare finding for any small pet on this site. This package reflects current guidance, cross-checked against the veterinary and behavioral sources on page 36, not the back of a starter-kit box.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An exotic or small-mammal vet. This matters more than the hamster's size suggests: a hamster's metabolism runs fast enough that conditions progress in hours rather than days, and wet tail can be fatal within 24 to 48 hours. Find a practice that sees rodents before you need one, and write the number on page 26 today.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> for the Syrian. Dwarfs are <i>Phodopus</i> species, and the Chinese is <i>Cricetulus griseus</i>
Adult size	Syrian 5 to 7 in (13 to 18 cm) and 4 to 7 oz (115 to 200 g). Dwarfs roughly half that
Lifespan	Syrians 2 to 3 years, dwarfs 1.5 to 2.5. A large veterinary study found a median age at death of just 1.75 years
Native range	Northern Syria and southern Turkey, in arid steppe and farmland, living in extensive burrow systems
Diet type	Omnivore. A complete pellet or lab block as the staple, plus small fresh amounts and insect protein (page 11)
Floor space minimum	700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm ²) unbroken for a Syrian, around 600 sq in (3,900 cm ²) for a dwarf
The one hard rule	Bedding deep enough to hold a real burrow. 6 in (15 cm) is the floor, the research used 40 cm (page 7)
Housing	One per enclosure. Syrians are strictly solitary and two together will fight (page 10)
Active hours	Nocturnal and crepuscular. Waking one during the day is the commonest way owners get bitten (page 15)
Legal status	Legal in 49 states and DC. Hawaii bans them outright, and a few states name only the Syrian (page 24)
Conservation status	Vulnerable (IUCN) for the wild Syrian hamster, despite how common the pet is

Fun facts worth knowing

- Nearly every pet Syrian is related. The species was brought into captivity from a single wild-caught female found near Aleppo in 1930, and almost every pet Syrian alive today descends from that one litter.
- Their cheek pouches hold about a fifth of their body weight. That is why you can go a day or two without seeing a hamster eat while it works quietly through a cached hoard, and why "hasn't eaten today" needs reading carefully (page 14).
- Bar-chewing is a measurement, not a habit. Wire-gnawing is one of the standard behavioral measures used to assess housing quality in small rodents, which is exactly why the bedding study on page 17 counted it.

SECTION 01

Cost overview

The cheapest animal in this series to buy, and the one whose setup costs most relative to the sticker price.

The hamster

\$15 to \$25 for a Syrian, \$8 to \$30 for a dwarf with Roborovski and Chinese at the higher end, and \$5 to \$15 from a rescue. There is no morph-driven pricing here the way there is with reptiles.

Every month

\$15 to \$50. Food is \$5 to \$12 of that; bedding and sand refills are the bigger recurring cost at \$15 to \$30, because deep bedding needs replacing to stay clean and dust free.

The setup

\$150 to \$350, with the enclosure the biggest line at \$30 to \$90 and bedding at \$20 to \$35 because you are buying a lot of it. Full breakdown on page 27.

The vet

A routine exam is \$40 to \$80. Emergency care, most urgently for wet tail, runs \$100 to \$800 depending on severity.

THE CHEAPEST ANIMAL, NOT THE CHEAPEST PET

This is the pattern worth remembering. A hamster costs less than a takeaway, and then demands a 700-plus square inch enclosure and six-plus inches of bedding that cost real money no matter how little the animal did. If the budget only stretches to the starter kit, the honest answer is to wait until it stretches further, because the enclosure is not the part you can economise on.

LIFESPAN CHANGES THE WHOLE CALCULATION

A large veterinary study tracking hamster deaths found a median age at death of **1.75 years**, with a range extending to about 3.65. Syrians tend toward the higher end at 2 to 3 years, dwarfs often shorter at 1.5 to 2.5. That is genuinely brief compared with almost any other pet, and it cuts both ways: less time to spread the setup cost across, but less lifetime expense overall, and a much shorter commitment to take on (page 23).

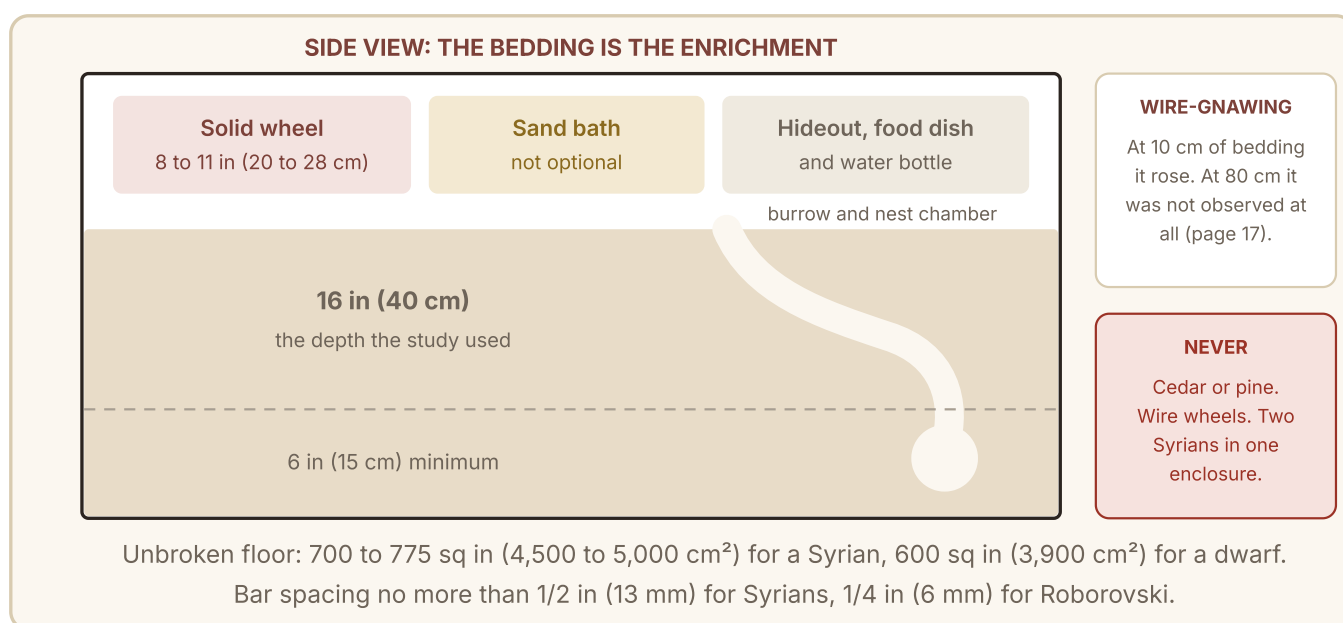
WHERE THE MONEY SHOULD GO

Enclosure first, bedding second, wheel third. Those three are the ones that decide whether the animal thrives, and they are also the three the starter kit gets wrong. Decor, tubes, and novelty items are the cheap part and the last part, in that order, and page 17 explains why the research puts them there.

Enclosure size & the starter-kit problem

Current welfare guidance calls for a genuinely large unbroken floor: roughly **700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm²)** for a Syrian and around **600 sq in (3,900 cm²)** for a dwarf, with more always better. A 40-gallon breeder tank works for dwarfs; Syrians do better in something larger still, a 75-gallon tank or equivalent. Unbroken is the operative word: a floor split by tubes and levels does not add up to the same thing.

If you use a wire cage, bar spacing must be no more than 1/2 in (13 mm) for Syrians and 1/4 in (6 mm) for smaller species, Roborovski especially, because they squeeze through gaps that look impossible. And the cage has to be tall enough at the base to hold the bedding on page 7, which is where most commercial cages fail: they physically cannot hold the depth, which makes cage choice and bedding depth the same decision.



NEVER USE COTTON-STYLE FLUFFY NESTING MATERIAL

The stringy white fibre sold in pet shops as bedding wraps around limbs and can cut off circulation, and hamsters pouch it. Plain paper bedding, shredded plain paper, or hay are all safe nest materials. Give the hamster the substrate and let it build the nest itself.

NEVER

Buy the starter kit and plan to upgrade later. It is too small for the floor space and too shallow for the bedding, and "we will get a bigger one soon" is how a hamster spends most of a two-year life in a box that measurably makes it chew the bars.

Bedding depth, and the study behind it

The single highest-value thing you can change, and the one no starter kit can accommodate.

What to use

Dust-free paper-based bedding or aspen shavings. Mixing a burrow-holding material with a looser one helps tunnels stay up instead of collapsing, which is the difference between a hamster that digs and a hamster that just redecorates. Avoid cedar and pine entirely: the aromatic oils in both irritate the respiratory system and are a direct cause of the infections on page 21.

How deep, honestly

DEPTH	WHAT IT GETS YOU
6 in (15 cm)	The commonly cited minimum, and a genuine welfare requirement rather than decoration. This is the floor, not the target
16 in (40 cm)	The depth at which every hamster in the study built a burrow and used it. This is the number to aim for
15 to 30 in (38 to 76 cm)	Veterinary guidance specifically notes depths in this range enhance welfare for Syrians, by supporting natural burrowing
31 in (80 cm)	The study's deepest group, in which wire-gnawing was not observed at all

Far deeper than most owners would ever guess a cage liner needs to be, which is exactly why it is worth stating in four rows rather than one.

THE STUDY, IN THREE NUMBERS

Hauzenberger, Gebhardt-Henrich and Steiger assigned 45 male golden hamsters to groups with 80, 40 or 10 cm of wood shavings. The 10 cm group showed **significantly more wire-gnawing** and higher running wheel activity. **Every hamster given at least 40 cm built a burrow and used it**, with significantly less wire-gnawing. In the 80 cm group, **wire-gnawing was not observed at all**. Depth is the enrichment, and everything else on page 17 is secondary to it.

Where to put the depth

DEEP ON ONE SIDE

If the enclosure cannot hold 16 in throughout, bank it: deep at one end for burrowing, shallower at the other for the wheel and dishes. Partial depth beats uniform shallowness.

PACK IT, DON'T FLUFF IT

Lightly compress the lower layers so tunnels hold their shape. A hamster cannot burrow through material that collapses behind it, and it will give up and chew instead.

DON'T EXCAVATE IT

Spot-clean the surface and the latrine corner. Do not dig out the burrow to clean weekly: you are demolishing the thing this whole page is about.

The wheel, the sand bath & the rest

The wheel: solid, and properly sized

A solid-surface wheel with no rungs is essential. Wire and mesh wheels cause foot injuries, and there is no version of that trade-off worth making. Size matters just as much: Syrians need at least an **8 to 11 in (20 to 28 cm)** wheel and dwarfs **6 to 8 in (15 to 20 cm)**. A wheel that is too small forces an arched running posture that is not good for the spine over time. The test is simple: a hamster should run with a flat back, not a curved one.

DON'T READ THE ODOMETER AS A WELFARE SCORE

This comes straight from the bedding study: the hamsters on shallow bedding ran *more*. Heavy wheel use is not automatically the sign of a happy animal, and it can accompany exactly the same setup that produces bar-chewing. Provide the wheel because a hamster needs one. Do not use how much it runs as evidence the rest of the setup is right.

The sand bath, which is not an extra

A dust-free, non-clumping sand bath is a genuine species essential. Hamsters use it to manage coat and skin oils the way a bird uses a dust bath, and skipping it is not a minor omission. Use reptile-grade or children's play sand that has been sifted and baked, in a heavy dish deep enough to roll in, and change it when it clumps or smells. Do not use chinchilla dust, which is far finer and irritates hamster airways, and never use anything labelled clumping.

Cover, tunnels and foraging

Hamsters are prey animals and cross open ground reluctantly. Connected cover, buried tunnel sections, and scattered hides change how much of the enclosure gets used at all, which is measurable and is the point: a large enclosure the animal will not cross is a small enclosure. Scatter-feeding rather than bowl-feeding turns a two-minute event into a foraging session, and it costs nothing.

The rest of the list

- A hideout, which is not optional either. A hamster with nowhere to hide is a chronically stressed one.
- A valveless sipper bottle, checked daily for leaks, or a heavy shallow dish.
- A food dish, though most of the food should be scattered rather than served.
- Chew items: untreated wood blocks, sticks, and plain cardboard, which are what keeps the incisors down (page 20).
- A digital thermometer, so the room's temperature is a reading rather than a guess (page 9).
- A small kitchen scale in grams, for the weekly weigh-in on page 33.

SKIP THE EXERCISE BALL

A hamster in a plastic ball cannot see where it is going, cannot smell the ground it is crossing, cannot stop, and cannot get away from anything. Ventilation slots also catch feet and toes. It is sold as enrichment and it is the opposite. If you want the hamster out of the enclosure, use a sealed, escape-proof playpen on the floor with cover in it, supervised.

Temperature, torpor & lighting

No heat lamp, no UVB, and one temperature threshold that genuinely matters.

RANGE	WHAT IT MEANS
65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C)	The comfortable range, kept stable. A normal indoor room, with no supplemental heat needed
Below 65°F (18°C)	Sources put the torpor threshold here or a little lower. Appetite and activity drop first, and this is where to start paying attention
Below 60°F (15°C)	Real risk of torpor, a hibernation-like state that can be dangerous and looks alarmingly like death (page 22)
Above 80°F (27°C)	Heat stress. Hamsters cannot sweat and a burrowing animal in a warm room has nowhere cooler to go

Sources differ slightly on where torpor begins, with 60°F and 65°F both cited. Treat 65°F as the line to act on rather than the line where harm starts, because the margin costs you nothing.

Keeping it stable

- Put a digital thermometer in the room, at the height of the enclosure rather than up a wall, and read it rather than judging by how the room feels to you.
- Keep the enclosure out of direct sun, off the floor where cold air pools, and away from a radiator, a draught, or an exterior door.
- In a cold snap, move the enclosure to the warmest room rather than adding a heat source you cannot regulate. Deep bedding is its own insulation.
- In a heat wave, move to the coolest room, add airflow, and give a ceramic tile in the shade to lie against. Never a frozen block a hamster can lie on directly.

TORPOR IS NOT HIBERNATION

Pet hamsters do not undergo true hibernation. What cold produces is torpor: a hibernation-like state with minimal activity and little or no eating, and a hamster in it can feel cool and stiff and appear dead. Gradual warming is the first response, never sudden heat. Page 22 covers how to tell the two apart, which is worth reading before you ever need it.

Lighting

No special lighting and no UVB required. A normal day and night cycle is sufficient. The thing worth remembering is that this is a nocturnal species, so bright light during its active hours is disruptive rather than helpful: a lamp left on over the enclosure in the evening is working against the animal. Keep the room dark at night, and if you want to watch a hamster being active, a dim red light disturbs it least.

WHERE TO PUT THE ENCLOSURE

Somewhere with a stable temperature, out of direct sun, off the floor, away from a television or a speaker, and not in a bedroom if you are a light sleeper. A hamster is loudest at 2am, which is a genuine consideration and not a joke: a badly placed enclosure ends up moved to a colder, quieter room, and that is how the temperature problem starts.

Choosing a hamster, and where from

Temperament varies more by species than most people expect. A Syrian and a Roborovski, both sold as "hamster," are genuinely different pets.

SPECIES	HANDLING	WHAT TO KNOW
Syrian golden, teddy bear	BEST	The largest and the easiest to tame, and generally the least likely to nip once settled. This is the species most people picture, and for good reason. Strictly solitary: two together leads to fighting, always
Winter White Russian dwarf	GOOD	Quicker and more easily startled than a Syrian, with a real chance of nipping when unhappy or cornered. Manageable with patience
Campbell's	GOOD	As above, plus a documented high susceptibility to diabetes, which makes the sugar rules on page 13 matter more (page 21)
Chinese	VARIABLE	Longer-bodied with a visible tail. Often calm, sometimes not, and also diabetes-prone. Frequently at the higher end of the price range
Roborovski	OBSERVATION	The fastest and least suited to regular handling of any commonly kept hamster. Robos tend to bite and cling rather than deliver a clean nip when startled. A genuinely rewarding animal to watch and a poor one to hold

NEVER HOUSE TWO SYRIANS TOGETHER

Not siblings, not a pair from the same tank, not "they seem fine so far," and not in any enclosure size. Wild Syrians are solitary burrowers and fiercely territorial toward each other, and that trait carries directly into captivity. The fighting is often silent and often fatal, and it typically starts as they mature rather than on day one. Dwarf species are sometimes kept in same-sex groups by experienced keepers, but it goes wrong often enough that one per enclosure is the safe default for every species in this table.

Where to get one

- A rescue is usually cheapest, and the animal comes with a known history and often an honest temperament assessment.
- A small breeder who keeps their animals on deep bedding is the best source for a well-started hamster.
- Pet shop stock is often young, sometimes mis-sexed, and occasionally already pregnant. Ask the age and check the sex yourself before you get home.
- Wet tail hits young Syrians between 3 and 10 weeks hardest, and transport is a trigger, so a shop-bought youngster needs the first week watched closely (page 19).

CHECK THE SEX BEFORE YOU GET HOME

A mis-sexed pair is how people end up with an unplanned litter, and dwarf species can be pregnant at purchase. Syrians are easy to sex once grown, from the very different rear-end profile. If you are buying two dwarfs on the understanding that they are the same sex, get that confirmed by someone who can actually demonstrate it, and have a second enclosure ready regardless.

Diet & the schedule disagreement

The staple

A nutritionally complete, species-appropriate hamster pellet or lab block, not a loose seed mix on its own. Given a mix, hamsters pick out the sugary, fatty pieces and leave the fibre-rich ones, which contributes to dental problems and obesity. A seed-only diet is specifically flagged as too high in fat and nutritionally poor. If you like the variety a mix offers, use a pellet as the base and scatter a small amount of mix as foraging material rather than as the meal.

THE SCHEDULE DISAGREEMENT, STATED HONESTLY

Sources genuinely differ. Some veterinary sources describe pelleted food as something that should stay **continuously available**, since hamsters are natural hoarders and rarely overeat pellets. Other feeding charts describe **twice-daily measured feedings**, roughly 2 tbsp a day for a standard-size hamster and about 1 tbsp for a dwarf, with a broader 1/8 to 1/3 cup range appearing elsewhere. Both approaches are legitimate. Pick one and stay consistent, and use the weekly weigh-in on page 33 to tell you whether it is working.

Reading a food label

A good hamster food lists a small number of recognisable ingredients and gives a protein figure. What you are avoiding is a bag that is mostly sunflower seeds, corn, and coloured extruded pieces, because that is a bag the hamster will eat selectively. If a mix is what you can get, buy it and use a plain pellet alongside as the actual staple, then scatter the mix as foraging material and expect to find the sweet pieces gone and the fibre left.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

A named formulated pellet or lab block. Around 16 to 20% protein for an adult. Short ingredient list. No added sugar, molasses, or honey.

WHAT TO SKIP

Anything with yogurt drops or honey sticks included. Mixes that are visibly mostly sunflower seeds. Bags with no protein figure at all.

CHANGING BRANDS

Over a week or two, mixing old with new. A sudden diet change is on the wet tail trigger list, which makes this worth doing slowly (page 19).

BUY SMALL BAGS, NOT BULK

Unlike hay for a rabbit, hamster food goes stale and loses vitamin content well before a big bag is finished, and a hamster eats very little. A bag you get through in two or three months is the right size, stored sealed and dark. This is one of the few places in this book where buying more is not better.

Portions, scattering & weaning

The schedule is disputed. These figures are not.

The parts with firmer numbers

FOOD	HOW MUCH
Pellet or lab block	Either continuously available, or about 2 tbsp daily for a standard hamster and 1 tbsp for a dwarf. Not both
Fresh vegetables	About 1 tsp a day
Fruit	About 1 tsp, roughly 3 times a week
Total fresh food	Vegetables and fruit combined, under about 10% of the diet
Treats: seeds, nuts, popcorn	1 to 2 times a week, under 5 to 10% of the total
Timothy hay	Offered freely as a chewing supplement, not a diet base the way it is for a rabbit
Water	Constantly available, checked daily for a leaking or blocked bottle

Scatter it, don't serve it

Hamsters are foraging hoarders. Scattering or hiding food around the enclosure rather than relying on a bowl encourages the natural behavior that is core to the species, and it turns feeding from a thirty-second event into something that occupies the animal. It also means you will find caches, which is normal and not to be tidied away wholesale, though a stash of fresh food needs finding before it spoils.

Weaning, if you have a litter

Dwarf hamsters typically wean around 3 weeks and Syrians nurse a bit longer, roughly 26 to 28 days, with all species fully weaned and self-sufficient by 4 to 5 weeks. Syrian litters must be separated before they mature, because the solitary rule on page 10 applies to siblings as much as to strangers.

INSECT PROTEIN IS NOT A TREAT, IT IS THE WILD DIET

Hamsters are genuinely omnivorous and eat insects in the wild. Mealworms or a little boiled unseasoned egg reflect that rather than indulging it, and they are worth offering regularly in small amounts rather than saving for special occasions. Two or three mealworms a couple of times a week suits a Syrian.

Food chart & the never-feed list

Staple, daily fresh, occasional, and never. Some of the "never" entries are genuinely disputed, and this page says which.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Complete pellet or lab block	STAPLE	The base of the diet. Plain and formulated, not a colourful mix
Broccoli, cucumber, bell pepper, kale, spinach, peas, zucchini, carrot	DAILY	About 1 tsp a day, washed, introduced one item at a time
Timothy hay	FREELY	Encourages the chewing that wears down continuously growing teeth
Mealworms, boiled unseasoned egg	REGULAR	Insect and animal protein reflects the wild diet. Small amounts, twice a week
Apple (seeds removed), banana, melon, pear	3× A WEEK	About 1 tsp. Extra caution with diabetes-prone dwarfs
Nuts and seeds, plain pasta, unsalted popcorn	TREAT	1 to 2 times a week, under 5 to 10% of the diet. High fat
Grapes	NEVER	Explicitly flagged as poisonous to rodents
Rhubarb	NEVER	Also explicitly flagged as poisonous to rodents
Raw onion, raw garlic	NEVER	Real hemolytic anemia risk. A couple of sources claim cooked versions in small amounts are lower-risk; treat that exception cautiously rather than as confirmed
Chocolate	NEVER	Toxic, as it is to most pets
Bitter almonds	NEVER	Distinct from common sweet almonds, which is a frequent point of confusion. If you are unsure which you have, do not offer it
Raw kidney beans, raw potato, eggplant	NEVER	All named as unsafe
Avocado	NEVER	Named as unsafe, as it is for most small pets
Citrus	DISPUTED	Genuinely disputed. Some sources avoid it entirely; a specialist hamster-food resource argues occasional citrus is fine for Syrians specifically, with extra caution for diabetes-prone dwarfs regardless. There is no cost to leaving it out
Sugary treats, honey sticks, yogurt drops	NEVER	Sold as hamster treats. These are the typical culprits behind diabetes in dwarf species (page 21)
Sticky or very soft foods	AVOID	Bread, peanut butter and similar clump in a cheek pouch and can cause impaction (page 14)

THE SUGAR RULE IS NOT COSMETIC

Campbell's and Chinese dwarf hamsters have a documented high susceptibility to diabetes, and a sugar-heavy diet is the direct route to it. Sticking to a plain formulated pellet as the base, rather than a treat-heavy mix, is the simplest way to avoid feeding into that risk, and it is far easier than managing the disease afterwards.

Why a hamster stops eating

Cheek pouches make this harder to read than it looks. A day of silence at the food bowl is not necessarily a day without food.

- 1. **Dental problems.** Cited as the single most common cause of appetite refusal. Continuously growing incisors that overgrow or get injured make chewing painful, so the hamster avoids food while still hungry (page 20).
- 2. **Wet tail.** A serious bacterial intestinal infection, especially dangerous in young or recently weaned hamsters, and fatal within about 48 hours untreated. Appetite loss is an early sign alongside soiled, wet hindquarters (page 19).
- 3. **Cold-induced torpor.** Below roughly 65°F (18°C), hamsters can enter a hibernation-like state with minimal activity and little to no eating. Gradual warming is the first response (page 22).
- 4. **Stress.** A new environment, handling, or cage changes cause a temporary, lower-urgency dip in appetite.
- 5. **Respiratory infection or other illness.** Usually comes with labored breathing, discharge, or lethargy alongside reduced eating (page 21).
- 6. **Diabetes in predisposed dwarf species.** Campbell's and Chinese dwarfs specifically, where it shows as appetite and energy changes alongside heavy drinking (page 21).
- 7. **Cheek pouch impaction.** Uncommon, but soft or moist food can clump and lodge in a pouch. Watch for one-sided swelling, face-pawing, drooling, and a sudden disinterest in collecting food. This needs a vet.

THE HOARDING PROBLEM

Because hamsters pouch and cache food, you may not witness eating for a day or more while the animal is fine and quietly working through a stash. Some can go 3 to 4 days on a pre-provisioned hoard. That is a completely different situation from a hamster visibly refusing available fresh food while showing other symptoms, which is the real emergency. **Check the cache before you panic:** if the stash is going down, the hamster is eating.

When to actually worry

ELAPSED	WHAT TO DO
6 to 12 hours, otherwise active	Worth watching. Check the cache, check the water bottle is not blocked, check the room temperature
12 to 24 hours, or any refusal with lethargy or diarrhea	Call the vet. The paired symptom matters more than the clock
Over 24 hours with no intake at all	Described as critical, given how fast a hamster's metabolism runs
Over 48 hours	Life-threatening

SEE A VET NOW, WHATEVER THE HOUR COUNT

Labored breathing or wheezing · wet or soiled hindquarters · discharge from the eyes or nose · a swollen abdomen · seizures · noticeable weight loss · a hunched, lethargic posture · one-sided facial swelling with drooling. Any of these alongside refused food skips the table above entirely.

Handling: getting it right

Most hamster bites are not a mean pet. They are a startled, disoriented nocturnal animal defending itself.

THE SINGLE MOST COMMON WAY OWNERS GET BITTEN

Reaching into the enclosure during the day while the hamster is deeply asleep. From the hamster's point of view that is not an attack, it is an ambush. Let it wake up and orient itself before you reach in, every single time, and handle in the evening when it is already up.

Getting it right

1. Approach in the evening, or wake the hamster gently and wait: rustle the bedding, speak, let it come up and notice you.
2. Offer a hand flat on the substrate with a treat on it and let the hamster climb on rather than reaching for it.
3. Scoop from below with both hands cupped. Never grab from above, which reads as a predator taking it.
4. Stay low, over a soft surface or sitting on the floor. Hamsters are quick and will jump or walk off a hand without checking what is below.
5. Keep early sessions to a couple of minutes and build from there, and end while it is still going well.

What to expect, by week

WHEN	WHAT HANDLING LOOKS LIKE
Days 1 to 4	None at all. Voice and smell only, from outside the enclosure. Let it dig and build a nest (page 28)
Days 5 to 10	A flat hand resting on the substrate in the evening, with a treat on it. No lifting. End the session when the hamster loses interest, not when you do
Week 2	Let it climb onto the hand and off again. Still no lifting. Repeat this until it is boring for both of you
Week 3	Short lifts, a few inches above the substrate, over the open enclosure so a jump lands safely. A minute at most
Week 4 onward	Longer sessions on the floor or in a lap, still low down. Some hamsters get to twenty minutes; a Robo may never get past the hand-climb, and that is a fine outcome

Reading the signals

Relaxed

- Grooming while on your hand, which is the clearest sign
- Pouching a treat rather than eating it in place
- Exploring outward rather than trying to get off

Stop now

- Freezing flat, or pressing into a corner of your palm
- Chattering teeth, or a raised paw
- Rearing up on the hind legs with the front paws out

A hamster that has had enough should be put down rather than reassured. Ending a session before it goes wrong is what makes the next one easier, and in an animal with two years to give you, the pace of the first month sets the tone for most of that.

The first week & common mistakes

Almost all of these are decisions made at the pet shop, in the ten minutes before the hamster came home.

The first week

Do not handle a new hamster at all for the first few days. Let it settle, dig, and build a nest, and get it used to your voice and your smell nearby. Then start with a hand in the enclosure, then a treat from the hand, then a climb-on, then a lift. Rushing this stage is what produces a hamster that stays defensive for the rest of a short life, and there is no way to make up the time later. If you get bitten, do not drop the hamster, which is the reflex and the way the animal gets hurt: lower your hands to the substrate and let it off, then work out what startled it, because a bite is nearly always information about the approach rather than about the animal.

Common mistakes

MISTAKE	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS
Buying the starter kit	Too small for the floor space and too shallow for the bedding, and both are the expensive things to redo (page 6)
Shallow bedding	Significantly more wire-gnawing and higher wheel activity in the research. The behavior owners read as personality is a housing readout (page 7)
Cedar or pine shavings	Aromatic oils that irritate the respiratory system, and a direct cause of the infections on page 21
Cotton-style fluffy nesting material	Wraps around limbs and cuts off circulation. Plain paper does the same job safely
A wire or mesh wheel, or one too small	Foot injuries from the surface, and a permanently arched spine from the size (page 8)
No sand bath	A genuine species essential rather than an extra. Skipping it is not a minor omission
An exercise ball	The hamster cannot see, smell, stop, or escape, and the vents catch toes. Sold as enrichment, and the opposite of it
Two Syrians in one enclosure	Silent, often fatal fighting, usually starting as they mature rather than on day one (page 10)
A seed mix as the whole diet	The hamster eats the fatty pieces and leaves the fibre. Obesity and dental disease follow (page 11)
Sugary treats, honey sticks, yogurt drops	The direct route to diabetes in Campbell's and Chinese dwarfs (page 21)
Reaching in during the day	The commonest way owners get bitten, and it teaches a new hamster that hands are an ambush (page 15)
Waiting overnight on wet or matted hindquarters	The most dangerous mistake in this book. Wet tail can be fatal in 24 to 48 hours (page 19)
Digging out the burrow to clean weekly	Demolishes the only structure the animal built, and the one the research is about. Spot-clean instead (page 7)
A general small-animal vet who does not see rodents	A hamster's problems progress in hours. The wrong practice costs the hours you needed

Enrichment: what the research says

Most small-pet enrichment advice is a list of things to buy. For hamsters there is a study with three numbers in it that reorders that list entirely.

The study

Hauzenberger, Gebhardt-Henrich and Steiger assigned 45 male golden hamsters to three groups with **80, 40 or 10 cm** of wood shavings and measured behavior, including responses to acute stressors. The results split cleanly. Hamsters on 10 cm showed significantly more wire-gnawing and higher running wheel activity than the other groups. All hamsters given at least 40 cm of material suitable for burrow construction built burrows and used them, and showed significantly less wire-gnawing. In the 80 cm group, wire-gnawing was not observed during the study at all.

WHY WIRE-GNAWING WAS THE MEASURE

It is not a quirk. Wire-gnawing is one of the standard behavioral measures used to assess housing quality in small rodents, which is why the study tracked it, and why "my hamster chews the bars" is a husbandry readout rather than a personality trait. The commercial default is nowhere near 40 cm, and most cages sold for hamsters cannot physically hold that depth, which makes cage choice and bedding depth the same decision.

Priority order

1. Bedding deep enough to hold a real burrow, 40 cm as the floor and more if the enclosure allows
2. An enclosure with the footprint and wall height to make that possible
3. A correctly sized solid wheel
4. Connected cover and buried tunnels, so the whole floor gets used
5. Scatter feeding and foraging
6. Novelty objects, last, and they are the cheap part

Cover, because a floor unused is a floor wasted

Hamsters are prey animals and cross open ground reluctantly. Connected cover, buried tunnel sections and scattered hides change how much of the enclosure gets used at all, which is measurable and is the point: a large enclosure the animal will not cross is a small enclosure. This is the reason space and cover are one item rather than two.

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't house Syrians together, since they are solitary and this is one species where companionship is the wrong answer. Don't use a wire or mesh wheel, or one small enough to arch the back. Don't read heavy wheel running as proof the setup is working, because the study found the opposite pattern. Don't use cotton-style fluffy nesting material, which wraps around limbs. And don't add accessories to a shallow setup and call it enriched, because the behavior that changed in the study changed with depth.

Health red flags & the exotic vet

SPEED IS THE WHOLE PROBLEM

Hamsters are hardy for their size, but a fast metabolism means conditions progress in hours rather than days, and a short lifespan means there is less margin for a wait-and-see week. Find a practice that actually sees rodents before you need one, ask directly how many hamsters they see in a year, and write the number on page 26 today. A general small-animal clinic that does not see rodents is not the place to discover this at 6pm.

Vet the same day

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT POINTS AT
Watery diarrhea, or a wet or matted rear end	Wet tail. Same-day, no exceptions (page 19)
Labored breathing, wheezing, open-mouth breathing	Respiratory infection (page 21)
Discharge from the eyes or nose	Respiratory infection, or an eye injury
A swollen abdomen	Bloat, an obstruction, or a mass. Urgent
Seizures, or an inability to stay upright	Neurological. Urgent
Cool, stiff, and apparently lifeless in a cold room	Possibly torpor rather than death. Read page 22 before you act
One-sided facial swelling with drooling or face-pawing	Cheek pouch impaction (page 14)

Book promptly

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT POINTS AT
Dropped food, drooling, weight loss	Overgrown incisors (page 20)
A lump or growth anywhere on the body	Tumor, common in older hamsters and particularly females (page 20)
Excessive drinking and urination with weight loss	Diabetes, mainly in Campbell's and Chinese dwarfs (page 21)
Bald patches, scabs, or persistent scratching	Mites, ringworm, or an allergy to bedding
Weight loss between weekly weigh-ins	The earliest number that moves. Bring the log from page 33

What to have ready when you call

- Species and approximate age, and where the hamster came from
 - Current weight and the trend from page 33
 - Room temperature, and whether it has been stable
- What it eats, and whether the cache is going down
 - Bedding type and depth, and when it was last changed
 - Anything that changed recently: a move, a clean, a new food, transport

Wet tail

Proliferative ileitis. The condition every hamster owner needs to recognize on sight rather than look up afterwards.

WHY THIS HAS ITS OWN PAGE

A large veterinary study tracking causes of death in pet hamsters found wet tail to be both the **most commonly diagnosed condition** in the species and its **leading specific cause of death**, present in roughly 7 to 8% of the hamsters studied. It can be fatal within **24 to 48 hours** without treatment. A condition that common and that fast is worth knowing before you need to.

Cause	Bacterial, and tied to stress. Transport, a new home, overcrowding, poor hygiene, or a sudden diet change are the usual triggers, which is why it clusters around the first days after purchase. It hits young Syrians between 3 and 10 weeks old hardest
Signs	Watery diarrhea. A wet or matted rear end, which is where the name comes from. Lethargy. A hunched posture. Appetite loss, often the first thing you notice. A smell. In a long-haired hamster the wetness can be less obvious, so check by looking rather than assuming
Response	Same-day vet, immediately. Do not wait to see if it improves. Treatment is antibiotics plus fluids and supportive care, and it works far better started early than started late. Keep the hamster warm and quiet on the way, and take the enclosure's details with you
Recovery	Genuinely possible with prompt treatment, and genuinely poor without it. Expect follow-up care and a period of supportive feeding. Full enclosure disinfection afterwards, and do not reuse the bedding

Prevention, which is mostly the first week

- ☐ Minimise stress in the first week home: no handling, no visitors, no rearranging (page 28)
- ☐ Keep the diet exactly as it was for a fortnight, then change it gradually
- ☐ Spot-clean the latrine corner daily rather than leaving it to a weekly clean
- ☐ Keep the journey home short, dark and quiet, and go straight home rather than shopping afterwards
- ☐ Look at the rear end every day for the first fortnight. It takes two seconds
- ☐ Never house two Syrians together, since crowding is on the trigger list (page 10)

NOT EVERY WET BOTTOM IS WET TAIL

Diarrhea from a sudden diet change, too much fresh food, or a leaking water bottle can look similar and is less dangerous. That distinction is a vet's to make, not yours, and the cost of treating a mild case as urgent is one appointment. The cost of treating wet tail as mild is the hamster.

Overgrown incisors & tumors

Overgrown incisors (malocclusion)

Cause	Hamster teeth grow continuously and are worn down by chewing. A lack of appropriate chew items is the usual reason they overgrow, and less commonly a genetic or jaw problem, or a tooth broken on cage bars. Once the teeth stop meeting each other properly, the overgrowth accelerates
Signs	Dropped food, or food picked up and put down again. Drooling, or a permanently damp chin. Weight loss. Pawing at the mouth. Reduced interest in collecting food at all, which in a hoarding species is a loud signal. Lift the lips weekly and look: the incisors should meet cleanly with no splaying or spiralling
Response	A vet, for trimming. This is not a home job: clippers on a rodent incisor shatter and split the tooth down its length, which causes abscesses and enormous pain. Expect it to need repeating for some hamsters
Prevention	Untreated wood blocks and sticks, plain cardboard, and timothy hay freely available. This is the reason hay is on the food chart despite not being a diet base for this species (page 11)

DENTAL PAIN IS THE MOST COMMON REASON A HAMSTER STOPS EATING

It is cited as the single most common cause of appetite refusal, and it develops quietly. That makes the weekly lip-lift and the weekly weigh-in on page 33 the two checks that catch it, because a hamster in mouth pain loses weight before it looks unwell.

Tumors

Cause	Largely age. Common in older hamsters and particularly in females, and one of the more frequent causes of death in an ageing hamster. A fast metabolism means they can grow fast
Signs	A lump anywhere on the body, often found while grooming or handling. Swelling of the abdomen. Weight loss, or weight gain that is really a mass. Sometimes hair loss over the site. Any new lump warrants a vet visit rather than a wait-and-see fortnight
Response	A vet, for assessment. Some are benign and some are operable, and the decision depends on the site, the hamster's age, and how it is coping with anaesthesia at that age. A frank conversation about quality of life is part of it, and page 23 covers that side honestly
Recovery	Variable. Surgery on a hamster is genuinely done and genuinely risky, and a small benign lump removed early has a much better outlook than a large one found late, which is the argument for the weekly hands-on check

MAKE THE WEEKLY CHECK A HABIT, NOT AN EVENT

Weigh, then run your fingers over the whole body: lumps, scabs, bald patches, a damp chin, a wet rear end, overgrown nails. It takes a minute, it works best during an evening handling session when the hamster is up anyway, and it is the only way most of this section gets caught early in an animal that hides illness and lives two years.

Respiratory infection & diabetes

Respiratory infection

Cause	Draughts, damp conditions, and dusty bedding, with sawdust, cedar and pine especially implicated. The aromatic oils in cedar and pine irritate the airway directly, and a dusty enclosure does the mechanical version of the same thing. Stress and a cold room lower the resistance that would otherwise cope
Signs	Sneezing, wheezing, an audible click, labored breathing, and discharge from the eyes or nose. Lethargy and reduced appetite alongside. Open-mouth breathing is urgent at any hour
Response	Always a vet, since these do not resolve on their own in an animal this small. Antibiotics and supportive care. At the same time, fix the cause: switch to clean, dust-free paper-based bedding, move the enclosure out of the draught, and confirm the room is not running colder or damper than page 9 allows
Recovery	Good when caught early and when the husbandry cause is fixed too. Treating the infection and leaving the cedar shavings in place is how the same infection comes back in a month

Diabetes, mainly in dwarf species

Cause	Campbell's and Chinese dwarf hamsters have a documented high susceptibility. Sugary treats, honey sticks, and fruit-heavy diets are the typical culprits, and a treat-heavy seed mix does the same job more slowly
Signs	Excessive drinking and urination, which shows up as a water bottle emptying faster and bedding that is wet more often. Weight loss despite eating. Lethargy, and a rough coat. In a small animal these are easy to miss without the weekly weigh-in
Response	A vet, who can test and guide a low-sugar diet. It is manageable rather than curable, and the management is mostly dietary
Prevention	A plain formulated pellet or lab block as the diet base rather than a treat-heavy mix, and no sugary treats at all for a Campbell's or a Chinese. Worth doing as a matter of course rather than waiting for symptoms (page 13)

A FEW OTHERS WORTH KNOWING

Mites and ringworm show as bald patches, scabs, and persistent scratching, and both need a vet rather than a shop treatment. **Bladder and kidney trouble** shows as blood in the urine or straining. **Abscesses** from a bite or a scratch appear as a firm swelling and need draining. **Cheek pouch impaction** shows as one-sided facial swelling with drooling (page 14). None of these is common enough for its own page, and all of them are a vet visit rather than a home remedy.

THE HUSBANDRY PATTERN WORTH REMEMBERING

Stress and poor hygiene are directly linked to wet tail, the single biggest threat this species faces. Dusty or aromatic bedding causes respiratory problems. A sugar-heavy diet raises diabetes risk in dwarf species specifically. All three are fully within an owner's control, and given how short a hamster's life already is, getting the basics right matters more here than it would with a longer-lived pet.

Torpor, and telling it from death

A cold hamster can look exactly like a dead one. Read this before you ever need it, because you will not want to be learning it in the moment.

What torpor is

Below roughly 65°F (18°C), and with real risk below 60°F (15°C), a hamster can enter a hibernation-like state: minimal activity, little or no eating, breathing so shallow and slow it is hard to see, and a body that feels cool and stiff. It is distinct from true hibernation, which pet hamsters do not undergo, and it is dangerous rather than restful. It is also one of the reasons a hamster stops eating (page 14). Check the room temperature first, because that is the single most useful piece of information you have.

Telling the difference

SIGN	TORPOR
Body temperature	Cool to the touch, but not cold and not hard
Breathing	Present but extremely slow and shallow. Watch the flanks for a full minute in good light
Whiskers	Occasional faint twitching, sometimes only in response to gentle warmth
Body	Limp or slightly stiff, but not rigid. Rigor mortis produces a genuine stiffness that torpor does not, and sets in within a couple of hours in an animal this small
Context	A room that has dropped below 65°F (18°C), often overnight or in a cold snap

What to do

1. **Warm the room, gradually.** Move the enclosure somewhere warmer rather than applying heat directly to the animal. Aim to get back into the 65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C) range over a couple of hours, not minutes.
2. **Warm the hamster gently.** Cupped in your hands, or on a towel over a covered warm-water bottle, never in direct contact with a heat source and never in water. Do not shake, do not submerge, and do not bury.
3. **Wait.** Rousing can take an hour or several. Movement usually returns before alertness does, and a hamster coming out of torpor is groggy and uncoordinated.
4. **Offer water and food once it is properly awake.** Not before, because a barely conscious animal can aspirate.
5. **Then call the vet anyway.** An episode means the room got too cold, and it can also uncover a hamster that was already unwell. If you are still unsure after two or three hours of warming, take the hamster in rather than deciding at home. Vets see this and will not think the question is foolish.

PREVENTION IS ONE THERMOMETER

Put a digital thermometer next to the enclosure and read it, especially through autumn and winter, and especially if the hamster lives in a room that is not heated when nobody is in it. Torpor is entirely preventable and the prevention costs about ten dollars, which makes it one of the better trades in this book.

Lifespan, ageing & the end

This is where hamsters differ most from nearly every other pet, and it is worth thinking about before you buy rather than after.

THE NUMBER

A large veterinary study tracking hamster deaths found a **median age at death of just 1.75 years**, with a range extending to about 3.65. Syrians tend toward the higher end at 2 to 3 years, dwarfs often shorter at 1.5 to 2.5. That is a genuinely brief commitment compared with almost any other pet on this site, and it changes what good care means: there is no long run in which to fix things.

What ageing looks like

- Thinning coat and bald patches, often over the hips and back.
- Less running, and eventually no interest in the wheel at all.
- Sleeping more, and being up for shorter stretches at night.
- Weight loss, which is why the weekly weigh-in matters most at this end of life.
- Stiffness, difficulty climbing, and reluctance to use levels or ramps.
- Cloudy eyes, and less certainty about where things are.
- Lumps appearing, which is the tumor risk on page 20.
- Longer, less tidy nails, since a less active hamster wears them down less.

Adjusting the setup for an old hamster

- ☐ Lower or remove high platforms and steep ramps, and take out anything a stiff hamster could fall from
- ☐ Move food, water and the sand bath closer to the nest, so nothing requires a journey
- ☐ Keep the bedding deep, but flatten a route between the nest and the essentials
- ☐ Offer softer food if the teeth are worn or sore, and keep the room at the warmer end of range

The end

Most hamsters do not die peacefully in their sleep, whatever we would prefer. The honest version is that a hamster in obvious decline, refusing food, unable to move around its enclosure, or with an advanced mass, is suffering in a body that cannot recover, and a vet can end that gently. Euthanasia for a hamster is quick, humane, and inexpensive, and choosing it early is a kindness rather than a failure. Ask what it costs and what it involves at the wellness visit rather than at the emergency one.

TWO YEARS IS NOT A SMALL THING

A short life is not a lesser one, and it is not a reason to invest less. It is the argument for getting the enclosure, the bedding and the diet right on day one rather than improving them over years you do not have. A hamster given a proper burrow for eighteen months has had most of its life the way the research says it should be, and that is a better outcome than a decade of gradual improvement would be here.

Where hamsters are not legal

The most legal exotic-adjacent pet in the United States. One state says no, and two more clear only the golden hamster by name.

Hawaii is the only ban

Mesocricetus auratus appears on Hawaii's List of Restricted Animals under Part A, which is headed "for research and exhibition," and that heading is the whole answer: Part A animals may be brought in by a university or a licensed exhibitor under permit, and may not be kept as pets. There is no separate pet permit to apply for. The reason is not about hamsters specifically. Hawaii runs an inverted rule under which introduction of live animals is prohibited except for those on the approved lists, so everything is barred unless something clears it. The concern is escape and establishment, the same reason the state bans every snake.

Where the rule names a species

WHERE	WHAT THE RULE NAMES	WHY IT MATTERS
California	Golden hamsters and dwarf hamsters of the genus <i>Phodopus</i> , both cleared by name	The clearest wording in the country, and it covers what people actually keep
Rhode Island	<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> and <i>Phodopus</i> sp., as domestic animals	Both groups again, listed among dogs, cats and rabbits
Alaska	Hamster (golden), <i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> , and nothing else	A closed list. Dwarf hamsters are not on it
Wyoming	Domesticated hamster (<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i>)	The same single species on a closed domesticated-animal list
Georgia	Genus <i>Mesocricetus</i> , excepted from the restricted rodent order	An exception written by genus rather than by species

Alaska and Wyoming are the ones to notice. Both work from closed lists, both name only the golden hamster, and neither mentions *Phodopus*. Read strictly, a Roborovski or a winter white is not the animal the rule cleared. In practice nobody is checking a dwarf hamster at a state line, but if you want the paperwork to match the animal, that is the gap.

CHECK THREE LEVELS, NOT ONE

State law is the first. A city or county can restrict what the state permits. And a lease or an HOA agreement can prohibit an animal that is perfectly legal where you live, which is the level that catches most keepers out. This page is a snapshot and a starting point, not legal advice: confirm current local rules yourself before you buy.

IF YOU ARE MOVING

Assume no until you find the animal on a list, and check before the removal van rather than after. Hawaii is the hard case: there is no pet permit to apply for, no quarantine route, and no exception, so a hamster cannot come with you. Rehoming to a friend before the move is the only workable answer, and it is far better arranged in advance than discovered at the airport.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Enclosure with 700+ sq in (4,500 cm²) unbroken floor for a Syrian
- ☐ Walls tall enough at the base to hold deep bedding
- ☐ Bar spacing 1/2 in (13 mm) max, 1/4 in (6 mm) for Robos
- ☐ Dust-free paper bedding or aspen, enough for 16 in (40 cm)
- ☐ Solid wheel: 8 to 11 in (20 to 28 cm) Syrian, 6 to 8 in (15 to 20 cm) dwarf
- ☐ Dust-free, non-clumping sand and a heavy dish for the sand bath
- ☐ Hideout, and connected cover or buried tunnel sections
- ☐ Valveless sipper bottle, or a heavy shallow dish
- ☐ Food dish, though most food gets scattered
- ☐ Complete pellet or lab block, plus timothy hay
- ☐ Untreated wood chews and plain cardboard
- ☐ Digital thermometer, and a kitchen scale in grams

Targets

TARGET	FIGURE
Floor space, Syrian	700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm ²)
Floor space, dwarf	Around 600 sq in (3,900 cm ²)
Bedding depth	6 in (15 cm) floor, 16 in (40 cm) target
Room temperature	65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C), stable
Fresh food	1 tsp vegetables daily, 1 tsp fruit 3× a week, under 10% of the diet
Treats	1 to 2 times a week, under 5 to 10% of the diet
Occupancy	One per enclosure, always
Vet	Annual wellness exam with an exotic or rodent-seeing practice

Before your hamster comes home

- ☐ Enclosure set up and bedding in, several days before arrival
- ☐ Rodent-seeing vet found, and the number written on page 26
- ☐ Species chosen deliberately, and its sex confirmed (page 10)
- ☐ A week of whatever food the seller uses, so nothing changes at once

Emergency & quick targets

VET THE SAME DAY IF

Watery diarrhea, or a wet or matted rear end, which is wet tail · labored or open-mouth breathing, wheezing · discharge from the eyes or nose · a swollen abdomen · seizures or an inability to stay upright · one-sided facial swelling with drooling · over 24 hours with no food intake at all · any refusal to eat alongside lethargy or diarrhea

COOL, STIFF AND APPARENTLY LIFELESS?

Check the room temperature before you assume the worst. Below 65°F (18°C) this is far more likely to be torpor than death. Watch the flanks for a full minute for very slow, shallow breathing. Warm the room gradually, cup the hamster in your hands, do not shake it and never put it in water. Full method on page 22.

READING	TARGET
Room temperature	65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C)
Bedding depth	6 in (15 cm) floor, 16 in (40 cm) target
Fresh vegetables	About 1 tsp a day
Fruit and treats	1 tsp fruit 3× a week; treats 1 to 2× a week
Occupancy	One hamster per enclosure

Your details

Hamster's name and species _____ Normal weight, in grams _____
 Vet that sees rodents _____ Date of birth, or arrival date _____
 Out-of-hours clinic _____ Last wellness exam _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Species and approximate age. Current weight and the trend from page 33. Room temperature, and whether it has been stable. What it eats, and whether the food cache is going down. Bedding type and depth. Anything that changed recently: a move, a clean, a new food, or transport, since all four are wet tail triggers.

Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear, the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Enclosure, 700+ sq in: bin, wire, or glass tank	\$30 to \$90
Solid exercise wheel, correctly sized	\$15 to \$30
Bedding, enough for real depth	\$20 to \$35
Sand for the sand bath, plus a heavy dish	\$10 to \$20
Hideout	\$10 to \$15
Tunnels and connected cover	\$15 to \$35
Food and water dishes, or a sipper bottle	\$10 to \$15
Chew items: wood blocks and sticks	\$10 to \$20
Digital thermometer	\$10 to \$15
Kitchen scale in grams	\$10 to \$20
First bag of pellets or lab blocks	\$10 to \$15
Equipment subtotal	\$150 to \$310
The hamster: Syrian \$15 to \$25, dwarf \$8 to \$30, rescue \$5 to \$15	\$5 to \$30
All-in before the hamster arrives	\$155 to \$340

Most first-time setups land around \$150 to \$350. Going deeper on bedding than the minimum pushes that up, and it is the line worth pushing up.

ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Pellets or lab blocks	\$30 to \$50 a year
Fresh vegetables, small amounts	\$20 to \$40 a year
Bedding replacement	\$60 to \$100 a year
Sand refills	\$15 to \$30 a year
Chew toys and wood blocks	\$15 to \$25 a year
Annual wellness exam, exotic practice	\$40 to \$80
Monthly, averaged	\$15 to \$50

Bedding is the biggest recurring line, because deep bedding needs regular replacing to stay clean and dust free. Emergency care, most urgently for wet tail, runs \$100 to \$800 depending on severity.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The enclosure and the bedding, in that order, because between them they are what the research measured. Buy the enclosure once and buy it bigger than the kit, then buy bedding in the largest bag you can store. Decor, tubes and novelty items are the cheap part and the last part, and no amount of them substitutes for the first two.

First 30 days checklist

The first week is mostly about leaving the hamster alone, because stress is the wet tail trigger.

Before day 1

- ☐ Enclosure set up and bedding in several days early, so it is settled and dust has cleared
- ☐ Room temperature confirmed at 65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C) on a thermometer, not by feel
- ☐ Rodent-seeing vet found and written on page 26

Day 1

- ☐ Go straight home from the shop. Short, dark, quiet journey, and no errands on the way
- ☐ Tip the hamster gently into the enclosure with some of its old bedding, then walk away
- ☐ No handling, no visitors, no photographs. Lights off and leave it
- ☐ Weigh in grams if you can do it without a chase, and note the arrival details on page 34

Week 1: the wet tail window

- ☐ Look at the rear end every single day. Any wetness or matting is a same-day vet visit (page 19)
- ☐ Keep the diet exactly as the seller had it. Change nothing
- ☐ Hands off. Sit nearby and talk, so your voice and smell become ordinary
- ☐ Spot-clean the latrine corner daily, and leave the rest of the bedding alone

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Start handling in the evening: hand flat on the substrate, treat on the palm, let it climb on (page 15)
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 33 with a weekly weigh-in
- ☐ Begin transitioning food to your chosen brand, mixed gradually over a week or two
- ☐ Introduce fresh vegetables one item at a time, a teaspoon at a time

Week 4 and beyond

- ☐ First proper weekly check: lift the lips for the incisors, run fingers over the body for lumps (page 20)
- ☐ Book the wellness exam, and ask them to check the teeth while the hamster is there
- ☐ Review the log for weight trend and whether the food cache is going down
- ☐ Add depth or cover from page 34 if the hamster is chewing bars, and fill in the sitter sheet on page 32

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Watery diarrhea, wet or matted rear end	Wet tail	Same-day vet, no exceptions (page 19)
Cool, stiff, apparently lifeless in a cold room	Torpor, not death	Check the room temperature, warm gradually (page 22)
Wheezing, clicking, open-mouth breathing	Respiratory infection	Vet, and switch off cedar or pine bedding (page 21)
Eye or nose discharge	Respiratory infection or eye injury	Vet promptly (page 21)
Dropped food, drooling, damp chin	Overgrown incisors	Vet for trimming. Never trim at home (page 20)
One-sided facial swelling, face-pawing	Cheek pouch impaction	Vet. Do not try to empty the pouch (page 14)
A lump anywhere on the body	Tumor, common in older females	Vet for assessment rather than watching it (page 20)
Heavy drinking, wet bedding, weight loss	Diabetes in a Campbell's or Chinese dwarf	Vet. Cut all sugar immediately (page 21)
Not seen eating for a day, cache going down	Normal hoarding	Nothing. Check the cache before you worry (page 14)
Refusing available food with lethargy	Several possible causes	Vet, and bring the Owner Log (page 33)
Chewing the bars persistently	Bedding too shallow, enclosure too small	Add depth. This is a housing readout (page 17)
Running the wheel constantly	Possibly the same as above	Don't read it as contentment. Check depth (page 8)
Bald patches, scabs, persistent scratching	Mites, ringworm, or a bedding allergy	Vet, not a shop treatment (page 21)
Bar-biting your fingers when you reach in	Startled, asleep, or hand smells of food	Handle in the evening, wash hands first (page 15)
Weight loss between weekly weigh-ins	Teeth first, then everything else	Lift the lips, then vet (pages 20 and 33)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Read the thermometer. This is the check that prevents page 22
- ☐ Refresh water, and confirm the bottle is not blocked or leaking
- ☐ Scatter the day's food, and remove any fresh food left from yesterday
- ☐ Spot-clean the latrine corner. Leave the burrow alone
- ☐ Look at the hamster in the evening: posture, breathing, and the rear end

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it on page 33
- ☐ Lift the lips and check the incisors meet cleanly (page 20)
- ☐ Run fingers over the whole body for lumps, scabs and bald patches
- ☐ Sift or change the sand bath, and top up bedding where it has settled
- ☐ Check the food cache is going down, and remove any spoiling fresh food from it

Monthly

- ☐ Wash the wheel, dishes and hideout, and check the wheel still spins freely and silently
- ☐ Review the log for trends rather than single readings
- ☐ Replace chew items, and rotate or add one piece of cover from page 34
- ☐ Check nail length, especially in an older or less active hamster

Every 3 to 4 months

- ☐ Deeper clean: replace a section of bedding at a time rather than all of it, so the scent and the burrow structure survive

Seasonal

- ☐ Autumn and winter: watch the room temperature hard, especially in a room not heated when nobody is in it
- ☐ Summer: keep the enclosure out of the sun, add airflow, and give a ceramic tile in the shade
- ☐ Any season: dry indoor heating raises the dust in bedding, so buy dust-free and sift before it goes in

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam with a rodent-seeing practice, and ask for the teeth to be checked
- ☐ Reassess the setup against the hamster's age, and start adjusting for stiffness (page 23)

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. For many hamsters this page covers most of a life.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Weigh and review the log	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Teeth and body check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Partial bedding replacement	☐			☐			☐			☐		
Wellness exam	☐											☐

Power outages, travel & transport

A hamster needs no equipment running, so a blackout is purely a temperature problem. A journey is the one that carries real risk.

When the power goes out

Do

- Watch the room temperature, because below 65°F (18°C) this becomes the torpor risk on page 22 rather than an inconvenience.
- Move the enclosure to the warmest room, away from windows and exterior walls.
- Add bedding rather than heat. Deep bedding is insulation, and a hamster in a deep burrow copes far better than one on a liner (page 7).
- Drape a towel over part of the enclosure, leaving ventilation clear. Keep feeding normally.
- In a hot outage instead, move to the coolest room, add airflow, and offer a ceramic tile in the shade.

Don't

- Don't put an unregulated heat pad, a hot water bottle, or a hand warmer into the bedding or against the hamster. It cannot move away fast enough and it will burn.
- Don't use a candle, a gas ring, or a paraffin heater near the enclosure.
- Don't dig the hamster out to check on it. You would be removing the insulation that is doing the work.

OUTAGE KIT

A spare bag of bedding, a towel, a torch, and a battery thermometer. That is the whole kit.

Leaving town

TRIP LENGTH	WHAT TO DO
1 to 2 nights	Fine alone, with the water bottle full and topped up right before you go, food scattered generously, and a room that will hold its temperature while the heating is off
3 to 5 nights	A sitter to check the water bottle, add food, glance at the rear end, and confirm the room temperature. Every other day is enough for a healthy adult
Over 5 nights	A sitter every other day who has done a practice visit with you, or better, the whole enclosure moved to their house if it can travel in one piece. Leave page 32 filled in

Transport and moving

- A small, secure, ventilated carrier with a couple of inches of the hamster's own bedding, some food, and a piece of cucumber for moisture rather than a sloshing water bottle. Small and snug travels better than roomy.
- Keep the journey short, dark and quiet, and go straight there. Transport is a documented wet tail trigger, which is the reason the first week home matters as much as it does (page 19).
- Never leave the carrier in a parked car, hot or cold, and never in a car boot. Wedge it in a footwell where the temperature is even.
- Moving house: move the enclosure intact if you can, bedding and all. If you cannot, bring as much of the old bedding as possible to rebuild with, so the scent survives the move. Expect a quiet, hidden hamster for several days, and watch the rear end daily for a fortnight.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Hamster's name and species _____

Where the food and bedding are _____

My phone _____

Vet that sees rodents _____

Out-of-hours clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- ☐ **Check the water bottle.** Refill it, then push the ball with a fingertip to be sure water actually comes out. A blocked bottle looks full.
- ☐ Scatter a small handful of the food from the labelled tub across the bedding, plus one teaspoon of the vegetables in the fridge.
- ☐ Read the thermometer and write it down. It should say 65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C).
- ☐ Find the hamster and look at its back end. It should be dry and clean. Coming out in the evening is normal; sleeping all day is also normal.
- ☐ Scoop out any soiled bedding from the toilet corner, and any fresh food left uneaten.
- ☐ Wash your hands before and after, and check the lid is properly closed before you leave.

Please don't

- Reach in during the day while the hamster is asleep. That is how people get bitten, and it is not the hamster's fault.
- Pick the hamster up unless we have agreed on it. It does not need handling while I am away.
- Dig out the tunnels or flatten the bedding. The burrow is the point, and rebuilding it is not a favour.
- Put the hamster in an exercise ball, or let it out of the enclosure.
- Feed anything not on this sheet, and nothing sugary at all.
- Move the enclosure to a colder or sunnier room.

CALL ME STRAIGHT AWAY IF

Its back end is wet, matted, or dirty · there is watery diarrhea anywhere in the enclosure · it is breathing with its mouth open, or wheezing · there is discharge from its eyes or nose · its belly looks swollen · one side of its face is swollen, or it is drooling · it feels cool and stiff and will not wake up, **which may be cold rather than death, so tell me before doing anything** · the room is below 65°F (18°C) · it has escaped

Owner log

One row a week, filled in on weigh-in day. In an animal that lives about two years, this is a short book and worth keeping properly.

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	TEMP °F	TEETH OK?	CACHE GOING DOWN?	LUMPS, COAT, BEHAVIOR, ANYTHING NOTICED

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

Weight is the earliest number that moves, and dental disease, tumors and diabetes all show up in grams before they show up to the eye. In an animal with a median lifespan of 1.75 years there is no long run in which to notice a slow decline, which makes a weekly number the only reliable way to catch one. Sixteen rows is four months, roughly a sixth of a hamster's whole life.

Equipment, cleaning & vet log

Arrival record

DETAIL	VALUE
Species, and sex	
Acquired from, and on what date	
Approximate age and weight at arrival	
Food the seller was using	

Cleaning & maintenance log

TASK	LAST DONE	DUE	DONE
Sand bath sifted or changed, weekly			
Wheel, dishes and hideout washed, monthly			
Bedding topped up			
Partial bedding replacement, every 3 to 4 months			
Chew items replaced			

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS, INCLUDING THE DENTAL CHECK	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment review, monthly

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Scatter-feed rather than bowl-feed, and vary where the food goes | ☐ Check the hamster is using more of the floor than last month, not less |
| ☐ Add or move one piece of cover, without demolishing the burrow | ☐ Check for bar-chewing, the readout that tells you bedding depth is short (page 7) |

Glossary

Cheek pouch	The internal pocket either side of the mouth that holds roughly a fifth of a hamster's body weight in food. It is why "hasn't eaten today" needs reading carefully.
Crepuscular	Most active at dawn and dusk. Hamsters are this as well as nocturnal, which is why evening is the time to handle one.
Diabetes-prone dwarfs	Campbell's and Chinese dwarf hamsters, which have a documented high susceptibility. It is why the sugar rules on page 13 are stricter for them.
Dwarf hamster	Winter White, Campbell's, Roborovski (all <i>Phodopus</i>) and the Chinese (<i>Cricetulus</i>). Smaller, faster, and generally more skittish than a Syrian.
Fossorial	Burrowing. Hamsters are a burrowing species, which is the whole basis of the bedding depth argument on page 7.
Hoarding	Carrying food to a cache rather than eating it where it is found. Normal, and the reason to check the stash before worrying about appetite.
Impaction, cheek pouch	Soft or moist food clumping and lodging in a pouch. Shows as one-sided facial swelling with drooling, and needs a vet.
Lab block	A formulated complete diet pressed into a hard block. Nutritionally complete, and it doubles as something to gnaw.
Malocclusion	Teeth that no longer meet correctly, so they overgrow. Almost always from too little to chew (page 20).
Proliferative ileitis	The clinical name for wet tail. The most commonly diagnosed condition in pet hamsters and their leading specific cause of death (page 19).
Sand bath	A dish of dust-free, non-clumping sand used to manage coat and skin oils. A species essential, not an accessory.
Syrian	<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> , the golden or teddy bear hamster. The largest, the most handleable, and strictly solitary.
Torpor	A cold-induced hibernation-like state in which a hamster feels cool and stiff and appears dead. Distinct from true hibernation, and dangerous (page 22).
Wet tail	See proliferative ileitis. Fatal within 24 to 48 hours untreated, and the reason page 19 exists.
Wire-gnawing	Chewing the bars. One of the standard behavioral measures used to assess housing quality in small rodents, which is why the bedding study counted it (page 17).

REFERENCE

Sources, version history & about

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary and scientific sources

- Hauzenberger AR, Gebhardt-Henrich SG and Steiger A. The influence of bedding depth on behaviour in golden hamsters. *Applied Animal Behaviour Science*. The source for every figure on pages 7 and 17.
- Behaviour of golden hamsters (*Mesocricetus auratus*) kept in four different cage sizes.
- O'Neill DG et al. Hamster health and disease in England, 2022. *Journal of Small Animal Practice*. The source for the wet tail prevalence on page 19 and the 1.75-year median lifespan on pages 5 and 23.
- Merck Veterinary Manual, providing a home for a hamster, for the enclosure and bedding guidance in Section 02.
- RSPCA, PDSA and VCA Hospitals on rodent diet, for the portions on page 12.
- ILAR Journal, environmental enrichment for laboratory rodents and rabbits.

Husbandry references

- SpectrumCare and SPAH on Syrian hamster care and health problems, for Section 03.
- HamsterNook, PetHelpful and Penn State on species differences, for page 10.
- Beastly Facts hamster guides: enclosure setup, feeding, health issues, handling, cost, enrichment, and the legal guide, current at the time of publication.

Version history

VERSION	WHAT CHANGED
3.0 · Sep 2026	Tightened from 42 pages to 36. Six pairs of pages that shared a topic were combined into one page each: species choice with where to buy, the first week with common mistakes, torpor with telling it from death, the two legality pages, power outages with travel, and the enrichment review folded into the equipment log. No husbandry figure, health red flag or target changed. Every block that came out is recorded in full in the package notes rather than deleted. The version number was also corrected to 3.0 to match the v3 template this guide is built on.
2.0 · Sep 2026	Rebuilt on the v3 package template at 42 pages, adapted to a small-mammal layout: the reptile heat, UVB and thermostat pages replaced with a single temperature and lighting page, and the freed room given to bedding depth on its own page, a species-choice page, wet tail on its own page, a torpor page, an ageing and end-of-life page, and legality. Adds both units throughout and reports the bedding depth study with all three of its figures.
1.0 · Sep 2026	First edition, on the earlier 22-page package layout.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources above and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an exotic or small-mammal veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit, which for this species means the same day rather than the same week. The legality page is a snapshot and a starting point, not legal advice. Free companion guides, updated as guidance changes, are at beastlyfacts.com.

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